

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 18: Health and Wellbeing in the Jewish Experience

August, 17-18, 2021

Online on Zoom

Physical Health and Mental Wellbeing Among the Portuguese Jews of Early Modern Amsterdam: Petition of Mosseh Chamiz Vaz addressed to the Amsterdam Portuguese community

Tirtsah Levie Bernfeld, Independent Scholar

City Archives Amsterdam, entry number 334, inv. no. 658, [no page number], 15 April 1742

Health care among the Portuguese Jews of early modern Amsterdam has not been a much-studied subject. Nevertheless, it was omnipresent and organized, both through public health care and private initiative. Health issues in the city and around could be very urgent, leading to crises, during epidemics and other natural disasters often hitting the area. Besides, many migrants joining the Portuguese community often arrived in bad physical state and needed immediate treatment. Nevertheless, it is difficult to get close to actual medical practice and learn through personal experiences of both medical doctors and patients. There was certainly a divide between the well-to-do using private health care and Jews on welfare lists who were bound by public provisions. It was only in the nineteenth century that the Jews of Amsterdam institutionalized medical care. In the meantime, the Portuguese communal leaders closely followed and supervised medical care provided, so costs would be curtailed. Nevertheless, it seemingly could not cope with the rising need of health care in view of the growth of private organizations to that effect during the 17th and 18th centuries. In this respect there are many questions to be asked, for example into what extent objectives formulated by public health care were translated into practice? Or, why the Portuguese community of early modern Amsterdam refrained from institutionalizing and modernizing medical care till the nineteenth century?

The source to be dealt with here, a mid-eighteenth-century petition, is unique in its sort as it leads us into the home-scene, focusing on the mental and physical state of an extremely sick person, not necessarily dependent on welfare, but still too poor to survive without help in one way or another. No assistants around as his young wife apparently took care of the well-being of her husband. On basis of the information provided by this petition, we could wonder whether health care, both public and private, was adequate. This source will be the starting point from where the structure of medical care among the Portuguese Jewish of early modern Amsterdam will be closely followed and analyzed.

Bibliography

Richard Barnett, 'Dr. Jacob de Castro Sarmiento and Sephardim in Medical Practice in Eighteenth Century London' , *Transactions of the Jewish Historical Society of England*, 27 (1982): 84-114.

Barrios, Daniel Levi de, *Triumpho del Gobierno popular y de la Antigüedad Holandesa* (Amsterdam, 5443 [1683]). Copies in the University Library Amsterdam, Biblioteca Rosenthaliana RON A 5252 and Ets Haim/Montezinos Library 2 F 81.

Esso Bzn, Izaak van, 'Het aandeel der Joden in de Natuurwetenschappen in de Nederlanden', in Hendrik Brugmans and Abraham Frank (eds.), *Geschiedenis der Joden in Nederland* (Amsterdam: van Holkema en Warendorf, 1940), 643-79.

Grell, Ole P., and Andrew Cunningham (eds.), *Health Care and Poor Relief in Protestant Europe 1500-1700* (London: Routledge, 1997).

Grell, Ole P., Andres Cunningham and Bernd Roeck (eds.) *Health Care and Poor Relief in 18th and 19th Century Southern Europe* (Hants: Ashgate, 1999).

Levie Bernfeld, Tirtsah *Poverty and Welfare among the Portuguese Jews in Early Modern Amsterdam* (Oxford: Littman Library of Jewish Civilization: 2012), see

index a.o. at Bikur Holim, *hevrot*, Honen Dalim, Maskil el Dal, medical care, medical help, private poor relief, the sick, surgeons, Temime Darech.

Lieberman, Julia R. 'The founding of the London Bet Holim Hospital in 1748 and the secularization of *sedaca* in the Spanish and Portuguese Jewish community in the eighteenth century', *Jewish Historical Studies*, vol. 49, 1(2017), pp. 106-143.

Lieburg, Marius J. van, 'Religion and Medical Practice in The Netherlands in the Seventeenth Century', in Hilary Marland and Margaret Pelling (eds.), *The Task of Healing: Medicine, Religion and Gender in England and The Netherlands 1450--1800* (Rotterdam, 1996), 135-43.

Pieterse, Wilhelmina Chr. , *Daniel Levi de Barrios als geschiedschrijver van de Portugees-Israelietische gemeente te Amsterdam in zijn 'triumpho del gobierno popular'* (Amsterdam, 1968), a.o. Bikur Colim, Temime Darech, Honen Dalim, Maskil el Dal, Resit Chogma.

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 18: Health and Wellbeing in the Jewish Experience

August, 17-18, 2021

Online on Zoom

Physical Health and Mental Wellbeing Among the Portuguese Jews of Early Modern Amsterdam: Petition of Mosseh Chamiz Vaz addressed to the Amsterdam Portuguese community

Tirtsah Levie Bernfeld, Independent Scholar

City Archives Amsterdam, entry number 334, inv. no. 658, [no page number], 15 April 1742

Mosseh Chamiz Vaz requests Your Lordships very submissively to have so much commiseration with my disgraced and deplorable state to assist me with some help for me as I am in a bed extremely sick , while I have no donkey milk [to drink] twice a day and lacking all what is necessary for me and for my inconsolable wife while Pesach is almost at hand, which I need to celebrate and I do not have the possessions to do it, seeking my brothers to help me, but they also have their families they need to take care of, making Your Lordships sure I would not bother you with this petition if it were not that I am dying in my bed and my beloved wife is assisting me night and day without having anything necessary for our food and assuring Your Lordships I am certain that if my brothers would see my miserable state they are and will be satisfied if you would anticipate me till one hundred guilders . Thus I ask that Your Lordships will assist me for the love of God and I will pray to God for this transition from death to life and for your health and that of this K.K. Vesalom

25 guilders is being sent out with the confirmation that the brothers agree to give these 25 guilders.

We signed below David and Joseph Hamis Vaz oblige ourselves at present as guarantors for our brother Moseh Hamis Vaz to the favor of the gentlemen parnassim of the Portuguese Jewish Nation as executors of the last will of our aunt

the lady Rachel Medina Hamis for the sum of one hundred guilders which the above mentioned gentlemen will be able to anticipate to our brother Moseh while we are satisfied that in case he would die it will be charged to our income accounts and we sign in truth 15 April 1742

David Hamis Vaz

Josseph Chamiz Vaz

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 18: Health and Wellbeing in the Jewish Experience

August, 17-18, 2021

Online on Zoom

Physical Health and Mental Wellbeing Among the Portuguese Jews of Early Modern Amsterdam: Petition of Mosseh Chamiz Vaz addressed to the Amsterdam Portuguese community

Tirtsah Levie Bernfeld, Independent Scholar

City Archives Amsterdam, entry number 334, inv. no. 658, [no page number], 15 April 1742

Mosseh Chamiz Vaz suplica a Vossas Mercês muy submesivamente tenham Vossas Mercês tanto commiserção de seu desgrasiado e deplorable Estado pera me assistir com algum socoro do meu pois que estou em hua Cama em extremo doente carresendo do Leyte de Bura duas Vezes ao dia faltandome todo o necessario pera alimentarme tanto a my como a minha desconsolavele e desgrasiada mulher com a pascua a maõ q se a mister fazer & não ter nhem huas posses pera o poder fazer, meus Irmaõs querendo ajudarme, mais tambem tenem suas famillas de quem terem cuidado, podem estar Vossas Mercês serto naõlhe emfadara com esta peticaõ senaõ fora q me veijo em hua Cama morendo & minha querida e povre Mulher assistendome de noute & de dia sem ter nhem hum necessario pera nosso alimento & asegurando a Vossas Mercês que estou serto q meus Irmaos vendo meu miserable estado estão e estarão contentes ainda que me anticiparem Vossas Mercês ate a soma de florins cento assy pesso que por amor de Deus me assistem & rogarey a Deus neste transito da morte para a vida & saude a VMS & augmento deste K.K.

Se despachou com f 25 com adisção que os senhores hirmãos ficão por dittos f 25.

Nos abaixo asinados David & Joseph Hamis Vaz nos obrigamos pella presente como fiadores per nosso Irmão Moseh Hamis Vaz a favor dos senhores Parnassim

da nação Judaica Portuguesa como executores do Testamento de nossa tia a senhora Rachel Medina Hamis pella soma de cem florins que os sobreditos senhores Poderao antesipar a do nosso Irmão Moseh contentandonos em caso de vier a falecer de que se carreguem em nossas contas de reditos e per verdade o firmamos em 15 abril 1742

David Hamis Vaz

Josseph Chamiz Vaz

Meus p^{re}ch Chamez Var Suplica al My muy submisivam^{te} tenha vny
 tanto commiseracao de seu desgraciado Deplorable Estado p^o me assistir
 Com algum Socorro do meu pois que estou em tua Cama em extremo doente
 Caruendo do Leyte de Muro duas Vezes aodia faltandome todo necessario
 p^o alimentarme tanto amy como am^o descomidavel de desgraciada muller
 Com a pascuca amas q^{ue} se amister fazer snas ter nlem tuas p^opos p^o poder
 Fazer, meus fmad^{os} querendo ajudar me, mais tambem temem suas famillas
 de q^{ue} terem cuidado, podem estar vny sento na d^olle em fadura Com esta peticao
 Schas fora q^{ue} me vejo em tua Cama morindo vny querda spovre Muller assistin-
 dome de noite e de dia sem ter nlem l^ou necessario p^o n^oso alim^{to}: Nasiguardo
 vny que estou sento q^{ue} meus fmad^{os} vendo meu miserable estado Estao Estera^{os}
 Contentes ainda que me anticipam vny ate usoma de florins cento ap^{ro}
 p^{ro}po que Hamos d^o me assistem e logarey ad^o neste transito da morte
 Hacida vande vny saugm^{to}: de te H.H.

Se Appaerou Com / 25
 Com adisao e os chamados
 fcaos p^o ditto / 25,

Vsalom

Morabau^{es} afmados David & Joseph Hamis Var
 Nos obrigamos pella presente como fiadores p^o h^oss fmad^{os}
 Morel Hamis Var, a favor dos Parnassm da naeas -
 Judanca Portugueses como exeutores de Espant de nosso
 Sia de Radrel Medina Hamis pella soma de legu florins
 q^{ue} o robedito b^o Poderas antefipar ad^o v^oss fmad^{os} Morel
 contentandome em caso q^{ue} n^ora fellecer de q^{ue} se carreguem em
 n^ora as Ambas de Redito, e q^{ue} verdade oformamos un 1^o abrel Var

David Hamis Var
 Joseph Hamis Var